

Social media can be very harmful to people's mental health, especially children.

Currently social media runs of a very strange business model. Social media current model is too maximize engagement []. They do this because they can sell the data gathered from you to advertisers. A general business model is make something that people want to buy, people buy said thing end of deal. If you are selling a service the customer buys the service for a set amount of time or until a task is complete, end of deal. The closest thing to the social media business is model is entertainment, specifically entertainment with advertising. The entertainment wants you to watch the adds so want your attention as long as possible. Casinos also fit this bill of wanting your attention as long as possible, because as long as you are playing they will be in general gaining money.

If you want to keep someone safe, you can wrap them in bubble wrap and force them to stay in the house. Unfortunately, you cannot protect this person from everything, there is always a small chance a big storm knocks over a tree and crushes the house with the person inside it. Also keeping someone as a prisoner even in there own house is in most scenarios frowned upon.

In society we generally don't restrict each other's basic rights. The UN has a nice list of beautiful rights everyone should have []. One of which is that you are free, meaning you should be able to do what you like. But you cannot harm others, this is of course too far, because that infringes on another's basic rights. How much potential self-harm does something need before it should be restricted? Lots of people think that suicide is not something that we as a society should allow, but some countries even allow that in some cases []. But most people do not think that society should restrict sky diving, even if there is a higher then normal chance to harm oneself.

This line becomes even more blurred when we consider drugs and alcohol. Some countries prohibit the consumption on alcohol and some do not. Both the USA and Canada prohibited alcohol at points throughout their history []. This back and forth of letting people do something that might hurt them without restricting a person basic right of free will is prevalent in lots of discussions. Should hard drugs be illegal to use? Should tobacco be illegal? Should gambling be illegal? Should marijuana be illegal?

These arguments of free will vs protecting people changes significantly when the people that are being protected are minors or children. The answer to all of the questions above, should x be illegal, were yes if you are a minor in Canada []. Children don't have fully

developed frontal lobes, the part of the brain that regulates decision making []. For this reason drugs and other addictive things are often illegal for children to use.

In Canada the laws have made it clear that we allow adults to do things that could potentially harm selves. If your act will potentially harm another is it not ok. It is illegal to drive drunk, because you are putting others in unnecessary danger. You are allowed to be drunk, but that drunkenness can not put others in harm's way. You are allowed to smoke tobacco, but there are now rules where you can smoke in order to protect those that would be harmed by the second hand smoke. Adults are allowed to gamble, gambling breaks the trend of harming others, if you lose all your money gambling there are no laws stopping you, even if you are responsible for a minor.

This leads us to the topic of social media, it has the potential to cause harm to the person using it. Should it be illegal? There is a debate that is maybe it should be. The debate is strongest when it is considering if we should ban social media for minors. But I would like to debate a broader point. Any business that users are there product should not be illegal for minors to use. That is a business whose revenue is more than 50% driven by data sold to third parties should be illegal for minors to use.

Just like gambling, tobacco, alcohol, and marijuana social media can be addictive.

When something is potentially harmful we as a society generally are fine with people still participating in this thing. For example, skiing and snowboarding are potentially harmful